

Attachment A – RFI Enterprise UAS Delivery Model Validation

Title

Enterprise Unmanned Aircraft Systems Delivery Model

1. Purpose

This is a Request for Information (RFI) only. It does not constitute a solicitation, and it is not an indication that the government will contract for any of the items and services discussed in this notice. The purpose of this RFI is to invite qualified vendors to provide information regarding their Unmanned Aircraft Systems (UAS) platforms, (purchasing and leasing options) sensors, payload options, software solutions, UAS Data Processing and Rendering Services) and overall system capabilities, in an effort to assess and identify various delivery models for UAS services.

Submission of a response to this RFI is entirely voluntary. Any responses received will be used by the Government solely for the purpose of making appropriate acquisition decisions. There shall be no basis for claims against the government as a result of information submitted in response to the sources sought announcement. The government does not intend to award a contract on the basis of this announcement or otherwise pay for any information submitted by respondents to this request. This notice is for market research purposes only and is not indicative of a full requirement.

Any information considered proprietary should be noted via appropriate markings. The government will use such information only to inform and support any potential solicitation and contract or for such other purposes as described within this RFI. Responses to this RFI will assist the Federal Railroad Administration (FRA) in identifying solutions capable of supporting potential operational uses such as railroad grade crossing inspections, accident investigations, site distance analysis, infrastructure assessments, and trespassing detection and evaluation.

Acknowledgement of receipt of responses will not be made, nor will respondents be notified of the outcome of the FRA's review of the information received. Additionally, the FRA does not intend to hold discussions concerning this RFI with any interested parties. However, FRA reserves the right to contact vendors if additional information is required.

Given the rapid pace of innovation in the commercial UAS market, FRA seeks to better understand recent advancements in UAS capabilities and the integration of such capabilities into FRA programs. This RFI is a follow-on to RFI Notice #693JJ6-DRONES originally published November 20, 2024.

This RFI will help FRA:

- Evaluate potential enterprise delivery models for UAS capability
- Understand commercially available UAS platforms and services
- Inform acquisition planning and lifecycle cost modeling
- Determine the most effective operational approach for a national FRA UAS capability

2. Introduction

The use of UAS technology is intended to improve the safety, efficiency, and effectiveness of FRA inspection activities by enabling inspectors to safely collect aerial imagery and data from locations that may be difficult, hazardous, or time-consuming to access by traditional methods. UAS capabilities should support the collection of high-resolution imagery and geospatial data that can assist inspectors with

evaluating conditions such as site distance, sign placement and visibility, roadway and rail infrastructure conditions, and other safety-related elements.

Additionally, UAS capabilities should support the development of mapping and measurement products that allow inspectors to perform measurements and document conditions associated with railroad safety inspections and investigations. The overall objective is to enhance situational awareness, improve documentation of inspection findings, and support data-driven decision-making that contributes to improved railroad safety outcomes.

FRA seeks industry input to inform acquisition planning and to understand how commercial solutions may support multiple delivery model approaches.

Potential operational uses may include, but are not limited to:

- Railroad grade crossing inspections
- Accident and derailment investigations
- Infrastructure and right-of-way assessments
- Safety situational awareness within railroad operating environments
- Site distance analysis and obstruction evaluation
- Trespassing detection and evaluation

Vendors shall identify any assumptions or constraints regarding UAV operations over railroad property, including coordination requirements, permissions, and regulatory considerations, particularly for contractor-operated models.

3. Operational and Data Requirements

See Attachment B: Technical Requirements

4. Delivery Model Evaluation

The FRA is planning the development and implementation of a 5-year UAS program. Prior to program implementation, the FRA may conduct a pilot phase (approximately six months) to validate mission workflows, operational feasibility, data processing capabilities, and delivery model effectiveness. The FRA is evaluating the following three primary delivery models for UAS capabilities:

- Government-Owned / Government-Operated (GOGO)
- Contractor-Owned / Contractor-Operated (COCO)
- Hybrid Model: Contractor-Owned, Government-Operated (COGO)

FRA is seeking industry input regarding advantages, limitations, and lifecycle cost implications associated with each model. Utilizing Attachment C: Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) Pricing template, vendors are requested to provide a ROM for UAS flight operations pertaining to one, or multiple, of the provided delivery models. The chosen delivery model (s) should reflect which model the vendor recommends as the best delivery model that FRA should consider for the 5-year program.

Vendors shall provide a comparative assessment of recommended delivery model(s), including operational control, staffing requirements, scalability, lifecycle cost drivers, and transition considerations between models.

FRA may conduct a pilot phase to validate operational feasibility prior to establishing an initial 5-year program. . Vendors should describe how their proposed delivery model would be implemented during a pilot, including operational control, staffing, and transition to full deployment.

Vendors should describe their end-to-end operational workflow, including mission planning, deployment, flight execution, data capture, and post-mission processing.

5. Security and Compliance

Total compliance with the following is non-negotiable:

- Section 848 of the FY2020 National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA)
- Section 817 of the FY2023 NDAA, and the American Security Drone Act of 2023
- American Security Drone Act of 2023 (FY2024 NDAA, Title XVIII): Formally bans federal agencies from using federal funds to procure or operate 'covered' UAS, effective as of late 2025.
- FAR 52.240-1: Mandatory clause prohibiting UAS manufactured or assembled by ASDA-covered foreign entities."

6. Submission Guidelines

For purposes of the RFI, the response shall include a cover page with the information requested below, not to exceed 8 pages of text; graphics, tables, diagrams, and spreadsheets do not count toward the page, as well as the Attachment C: ROM Pricing Template. The document(s) shall be prepared using Times New Roman 12-point font style for printing on 8.5 X 11-inch paper. Each page shall identify the submitting respondent and page number. Page Margins shall be no less than 0.5” on all sides.

Vendors are requested to complete Attachment C to facilitate a standardized evaluation of potential delivery models and associated ROM’s for UAS services.

Pricing responses shall align to each proposed delivery model and clearly identify key cost drivers including equipment, operations, staffing, data processing, and sustainment.

Vendors are encouraged to propose measurable performance metrics that could be used to evaluate operational effectiveness, including mission success rate, data quality, and response time.

A complete response to the RFI should include answers to all the information requested. Please note that a respondent’s failure to provide a complete response to the information requested will be interpreted to mean that it does not understand what information is being requested and does not demonstrate the capability to meet the requirement. Responses should demonstrate capability, not merely affirm the respondent’s capability (i.e. the response must go beyond the statement that, “XYZ company can provide O&M support”).

Please provide the following information about your company on the cover page (no more than one page).and not counted toward the 8-page limit):

- Company Name

- Your Company's Primary Business Product or Service Line
- Commercial and Government Entity (CAGE) Code
- Unique Entity Identifier (UEI) number
- Address Including Telephone Number and Email Address
- Points of Contact
- Size of Business Pursuant to North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) Codes
- A list of NAICS codes under which your organization currently provides UAS products or services. Please specify which of these codes your organization identifies as the most appropriate NAICS code(s) for the subsequent solicitation of this program.
- If applicable, state whether your company is Small Business; Woman Owned Small Business; Small Disadvantaged Business; 8(a) Certified; HUBZone Certified; Veteran Owned Small Business; or Service-Disabled Veteran Small Business; or a Large Business
- GWAC contract number: if your company has any NASA SEWP, GSA, NITTAC, or other GWAC contract through that the Government can buy the proposed solution, please provide the contract number and the expiration date and any option.

RFI Response Due Date/Time: 5PM EST 04/08/2026

Email all questions and responses to: kerianne.gallagher@dot.gov

Please include RFI #693JJ6FRAUAS and FRA Enterprise UAS Delivery Model Validation in the subject line of your email. In the email, include a primary contact name, title, organization, and contact information (phone number and email address) for any follow-up. No phone calls will be accepted for this notice.